works of Goethe, Schiller and Shakespeare: ‘There was hardly a field I was not interested in, from natural sciences to classical literature.’6 His good behaviour was enough to allow his parents, Karoline and Wilhelm, and sister Gertrud and her husband, Hans Hoppstädter, to visit twice annually. On one occasion, after a long, exhausting train journey from Wiebelskirchen, Wilhelm pleaded for his son’s draft into the army like his other brother, Willi, who was wearing the Wehrmacht uniform, courageously fighting in the Soviet Union (but was later killed during the retreat from Romania).7

Despite penning two petitions for clemency, Wilhelm was informed his son was denied parole because, as the SS declared, he remained a ‘convinced communist functionary’ and an ‘incorrigible supporter of communism’.8 Furthermore, it was reckoned that, if released, he would immediately return to the underground KPD.

Shortly thereafter, with the Allied bombing of Germany having taken a more dramatic turn, Honecker was drafted to conduct roofing work at the Arado airplane factory, though the unit was more often employed in bomb disposal in central Berlin: ‘When necessary, we carried the bombs some distance away, un-defused, on our shoulders,’ he explained. Before too much time passed, with trembling fingers, he was digging out the dead and wounded from caved-in air raid shelters and removing rubble from the streets. ‘When we got caught by a new bomb attack in the process, which happened more and more often, we were detailed to throw incendiary bombs down from roofs.’ (He was even commended by Attorney General, Erich Kolb, for his bravery in rescuing women trapped in a detention centre).

Throughout those days, as raids flattened homes and factories, the roofing detail mustered one hour before dawn for rations – bread, cheese and ersatz coffee. With the onset of winter, as travelling to Berlin became trickier, the team moved to Barnimstraße women’s prison, a squalid red-brick facility in Friedrichshain, near Alexanderplatz. It was there in November 1943 that Honecker witnessed ‘an image of hell’ when – in sub-zero temperatures – the RAF unloaded 2,500 tons of explosives in two attacks, which killed 4,000, injured 10,000, and left 45,000 homeless. ‘Alexanderplatz and